

Going Global: A SIG on the Challenges and Perspectives of Internationalization Within and Across the World of HCI

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ABSTRACT

As a premier international association for professionals, academics, and students who are interested in Human-Computer Interaction, SIGCHI has always been committed to diversity and inclusion. Over the years, SIGCHI Conferences have provided various venues to discuss matters that promote voices from diverse constituents. With this SIG, we would like to add to this effort, by bringing attention to barriers and opportunities for improvements in geographic inclusion at SIGCHI, and also highlighting efforts that were conducted before and might be adapted to address ongoing challenges. We will assemble a geographically inclusive group of participants in a roundtable discussion to share their insights based on their lived experiences with geographic inclusion (at SIGCHI and elsewhere), and encourage the audience to engage in discourse with them.

CCS CONCEPTS

- Human-centered computing;

KEYWORDS

inclusion, globalization, internationalization, global

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1 INTRODUCTION

The ACM Special Interest Group on Computer-Human Interaction (SIGCHI) is an organization that has now been around for over 40 years, sponsoring not only its flagship ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI) series, but also several specialized conferences in the field of Human-Computer Interaction, and supporting individual and community contributions in numerous ways. SIGCHI was born at a time when the field was just emerging [4, 7], at the Gaithersburg Conference in 1982. Since this pivotal meeting, SIGCHI has mobilized significant contributions to the humanization and ease of use of technology, driving societal impact through its support and strengthening of an ever-widening field of human-computer interaction (HCI). It is now one of the world's largest associations of interdisciplinary professionals and academics in the field.

Throughout its history, there has been a steady effort of internationalization [8]. SIGCHI gradually became more international, expanding chapters beyond US borders and bringing CHI to Europe for the first time (aka. INTERCHI, held in Amsterdam, in 1993.) This opened new opportunities for dialogue with other communities, practices and cultures. The considerable efforts made to organize that event and reconcile US and EU working processes and setup partnerships between ACM, IFIP and the Dutch Computer Society (NGI) shows us how important it is to identify partners in different locations and establish fruitful collaborations. Today, SIGCHI members come from many different socio-cultural contexts, circumstances and backgrounds.

Despite the steady global dissemination of HCI as a field, multiple regions and countries still face challenges embracing HCI. As a result, there are different levels of engagement and knowledge about the topic around the world, as well as different methods and practices. While some communities are strong and active, others

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have only a handful of people working in HCI, if at all. In many locations, strong communities exist but are not in contact with SIGCHI, and work done there often goes unnoticed by the SIGCHI community.

Many projects have been undertaken throughout the years to increase global participation in SIGCHI activities[8]. Nevertheless, there is much still to be done. SIGCHI would like to engage with existing communities around the world and itself become a more diverse community. It is important to think about and plan for these interactions, considering how to welcome international participants to our conferences as well as how to build fruitful partnerships with them. Despite the currently inequitable participation, there is potential for individuals and groups to step beyond regional boundaries, and to align and collaborate [1].

The overarching questions guiding the SIG are:

- What are the challenges faced by foreign participants (non-US/EU) in our SIGCHI events?
- What are the challenges when engaging with other groups? How should we engage with existing communities?
- What potential do we see for a future, more global, SIGCHI?

The pandemic showed us that it is possible to bring people of different cultures and in different locations together around certain themes, but in the “return to normal”, these interactions and global collaboration seem to be winding down. At the same time, technology has advanced greatly and created new possibilities for engagement that help create bridges and bring people together.

The current SIGCHI Executive Committee (EC), is committed to making our community more globally and locally connected. In line with this goal, a Global Committee has just been formed, to look at how we can best support communities across the world in participating actively and meaningfully in our community. This SIG is proposed by the SIGCHI Global Committee and VP for Partnerships (Susan Dray), with the goal of unpacking the challenges in global collaboration and also of shedding light on initiatives from local communities outside of the SIGCHI community, from which we could all learn.

2 SIG DESCRIPTION

This SIG builds on previous initiatives of this and past ECs meant to increase our international presence and be more receptive to global audiences. Events such as SIGCHI Latin America Committee panel at CHI 2022 [3], the SIGCHI Across Borders panel at CSCW 2021 [9], multiple Equity talks [1, 5] and initiatives from other conferences [2] evidence the importance of the theme. In an increasingly fragmented world, how can we build community and foster communication?

In this SIG, we aim to tease out the barriers to global participation and inclusion in SIGCHI and opportunities for improvement. We would also like to hear from participants in general about solutions they might have experienced which we may be able to adopt. In addition, we acknowledge that SIGCHI is not the only HCI organization in the world, there are multiple local and regional entities pursuing HCI in different ways in their regions (formal organizations and informal communities, both academic and practice based.) We seek to learn from the experiences of these sister organizations

and communities, hopefully bringing in a richer set of experiences to the spotlight and strengthening our own practices.

2.1 SIG Organization and Roundtable

To highlight different practices and challenges, we will setup a roundtable, including members of the SIGCHI Executive Committee past and present and representatives from different regions and organizations, to think about challenges and solutions. The roundtable will be moderated by members of SIGCHI’s Global and Partnerships Committees. A tentative list of roundtable participants is presented below (to be invited, pending approval of this proposal.) The final makeup will be representative of different voices and enable us to hear about challenges of international integration and how they were dealt with, and to learn about experiences in academic and non-academic global partnerships (successful or otherwise) and persisting challenges in different locations. Besides ensuring geographic diversity, the large number of participants should allow us to address a large variety of challenges and opportunities that present themselves both to the SIGCHI as an organization and to members individually, and to create dynamic interactions.

Anicia Peters is the pro-vice-chancellor for Research, Innovation and Development and an associate professor at the University of Namibia. Previously, she was dean of the Faculty of Computing and Informatics (FCI). She is currently serving as CHI23 Technical Program Chair.

Anirudha Joshi is a faculty member in the Industrial Design Centre, IIT Bombay. He teaches and does research in the field of human-computer interaction design, user studies and usability evaluation. He was co-chair of the program committee of the first India HCI conference (2004) in Bangalore, and past VP Finance for SIGCHI EC. He also represents India on IFIP TC13.

Joaquim Jorge is a Full Professor of Computer Science at Instituto Superior Técnico (IST/UL), and heads the Graphics and Interaction Group at INESC-ID. He is a Distinguished Member and Speaker for ACM and is affiliated with ACM/SIGGRAPH, for whom he has served as Small Conferences Committee Chair and in their Education Committee. He served on the Executive Committee of the ACM Europe Council from 2015 to 2019.

Kaisa Väänänen is a full professor in Tampere University, Finland. She served as a member of Academy of Finland’s research council for Natural Sciences and Engineering (2013-2018) and is currently serving as general co-chair of CHI23.

Koji Yatani is an Associate Professor in Department of Electrical Engineering and Information Systems (EEIS), School of Engineering, at The University of Tokyo. He is an ACM Distinguished Member (Class of 2022), and winner of the RIEC Award (2019) and of the IPSJ/ACM Award for Early Career Contributions to Global Research (2020). He served as a founding editor for Proceedings of ACM Interactive, Mobile, Wearable and Ubiquitous Technology (IMWUT) (2016–2020), papers co-chair for CHI 2022 and program co-Chair for UbiComp 2015. He was Steering Committee chair for UbiComp (2019 – 2021) and is currently a Vice chair for Japan ACM SIGCHI Chapter.

Leonel Morales Dias is a professor at Universidad Francisco Marroquín, Guatemala. He has been engaged with SIGCHI for over 20 years now, and also runs the SIGCHI Guatemala chapter.

Raquel Prates is a professor at the Federal University of Minas Gerais, and a Brazilian HCI Lifetime Research awardee. She was part of the early days of the Brazilian HCI community from its inception, and took part in the planning devised to help the community grow (Brazil now has a large and active HCI community.)

Shaimaa Lazem holds an academic position at the City of Scientific Research and Technology Applications (SRTA-City), where HCI was not a well-known subject until recently. She was awarded the Leaders in Innovation Fellowship with the Royal Academy of Engineering to support digital self-documentation of intangible cultural heritage. She is the Chair of the Cairo ACM SIGCHI Professional Chapter in Egypt (CairoCHI) and the Co-founder of the ArabHCI community.

Steven Pemberton is a researcher, author and public speaker affiliated with the Dutch National Research Centre for Mathematics and Informatics. A SIGCHI Lifetime Service Award winner (2009) and Lifetime Practice Award winner (2022) and SIGCHI EC member for many years, Steven was instrumental in the organization of CHI'93 (InterCHI), the first one held outside of the US. We hope to hear about the challenges faced at the time and define

Susan Dray is an ACM Fellow, Human Factors and Ergonomics Society Fellow, SIGCHI Lifetime Achievement in Practice Awardee, UXPA Lifetime Achievement Awardee and a founding member of SIGCHI. She has long been a strong proponent of initiatives to bring HCI to international audiences, and has run many events to strengthen HCI in different regions such as Latin America, Africa and Asia.

Moderators will include members of the SIGCHI Global and Partnerships Committees. We will also appoint note takers so later analysis can be conducted.

2.2 SIG Format

Prior to CHI23, we will analyze reports of previous SIGs, panels, blog posts and other resources to elicit a set of themes to address during the SIG. We will also solicit questions from the community beforehand, and try to include the most popular themes in the discussion. We will ask roundtable participants to prepare 1-2 questions for each other and 1-2 provocations for the whole room. In addition, we will try to promote at least one group meeting (online) prior to CHI23, so that roundtable participants can get acquainted with each other and plan on what to say.

We will set up roundtable participants as "discussants" to each other, to create interesting counterpoints and promote reflection (e.g., for someone like Steven Pemberton, possible discussants might be Kaisa Väänänen, CHI'23 chair, to reflect on the challenges of organizing CHI outside the US 30 years later.) To promote engagement, we plan to solicit real time participation using tools that can also enable participation from people watching remotely (e.g., Mentimeter, Sli.do or Kahoot.)

The first part of the SIG will consist of moderated roundtable discussion. Moderators will have prepared questions to tease out topics that can inform and guide audience participation. Following that, roundtable members will ask each other their prepared questions and also direct their questions at the room, to create an

interactive debate. For the final 15 minutes, we will ask the audience and speakers to discuss the challenges and think of potential solutions.

Some of the questions might be:

- How did HCI develop in your country/region? What contributed to its development and what hindered it?
- What are the main challenges for the establishment of geographically disperse collaborative networks?
- What organizational structures and initiatives can be leveraged for geographic inclusion?
- Are there barriers that prevent SIGCHI members from different regions to engage with SIGCHI? (not only at conferences, but also in other situations, e.g., awards, summer schools, etc.)
- Is there anything that makes it hard for members from your regions to publish?
- Is the human-computer interaction field organized in ways that make participation harder in different countries?
- How do the current global and regional challenges effect the growing community of SIGCHI?
- Are there special needs and/or outlooks of national HCI communities?
- How can we encourage communication and cooperation among communities?
- What HCI organizations and associations exist in your regions, and how could SIGCHI cooperate with these?

As mentioned before, we will also collect questions beforehand, to help engage more people in the conversation.

3 POST SIG ENGAGEMENT

We will conclude the SIG by encouraging the audience to participate in future Geographic inclusion activities and efforts. After the SIG, notes will be consolidated and analyzed for insights, and findings will be reported in an appropriate SIGCHI venue. In addition, we will engage with the community over the SIGCHI Discord. Back in 1997, the SIG on "Improving international communication and cooperation in SIGCHI" [6] highlighted the following challenges for internationalization (many others can be mentioned):

- Differences in intellectual and research traditions
- Practices and perceptions of SIGCHI within national communities
- Language barriers and problems in sharing HCI research and publications
- Differences in cultural traditions
- Differences in social and business interaction styles

In this SIG, we ask ourselves: how far have we come in these 25 years? Are we any closer to solving any of these? Are they easier or harder nowadays? What efforts have been conducted and how did they fare? We hope we like the answers we get in this SIG.

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